

Middle Schooler's Dyslexia Podcast Wins National Contest

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-10 5 min read

A seventh-grader from Long Island, New York, has won the middle-school grand prize in NPR's Student **Podcast** Challenge. Cora Walsh of Rockville Centre created a **podcast** called "**Dyslexia** and MEE" about her long path to understanding why reading was so hard.

Cora has **dyslexia**, a learning difference that can make reading more difficult. She said it took almost five years to get the correct **diagnosis**. For a long time she knew only that reading felt confusing, even when she practiced more than her friends.

Her **podcast** was chosen from nearly 1,500 **submissions** from 42 states and the District of Columbia. Cora said she felt excited about the win. Her mom, Emily Johnson, said she was proud of how hard her daughter works and of her positive attitude.

Cora has received **tutoring** for **dyslexia** for two years. In the **podcast**, listeners hear part of a Zoom lesson where she practices sounding out words while her tutor gives feedback. She says she is a better reader now and enjoys reading more. This summer, her mom saw her pick up the first Hunger Games book for fun on trips and even while reading to her pet rabbit.

Cora hopes the **podcast** will help **dyslexia** feel less scary for other kids who are still figuring out how they learn. She says she is proud that she kept trying and made something interesting for others to hear. She has already checked out the second Hunger Games book from the library.

Dyslexia does not mean a person cannot learn to read. With the right support, many students improve and find strategies that work for them.

Word Treasure

dyslexia -- A learning difference that can make reading words harder than expected.

diagnosis -- An official finding by experts about what condition a person has.

podcast -- An audio show people can listen to on phones or computers.

submissions -- Entries sent in to a contest or program.

tutoring -- Extra one-on-one teaching to help someone learn a skill.

Background you need

Dyslexia is a common learning difference that mainly affects how the brain handles written language.

Many students with dyslexia improve with structured reading practice and support outside regular class.

Student contests ask kids to research a topic and share it in formats such as podcasts.

Getting the right learning support often starts with understanding what is making schoolwork difficult.

Break it down

LEAD: Long Island seventh-grader wins NPR middle-school podcast prize

KEY EVENT: Cora Walsh's "Dyslexia and MEE" chosen from nearly 1,500 entries

+ - WHO: Cora Walsh; mom Emily Johnson

+ - WHERE: Rockville Centre, Long Island, New York

BACKGROUND: Dyslexia diagnosis took almost five years; two years of tutoring

EVIDENCE: Zoom lesson clips; summer recreational reading

OPEN QUESTION: How the podcast may help other students who learn differently

Why it matters

Winning a national student contest can spotlight learning differences and show peers that persistence and the right support matter. Stories like Cora's help normalize dyslexia and encourage kids still seeking answers.

Test what you remember

1. What prize did Cora Walsh win?

- ☐ (A) A national spelling bee trophy
- ☐ (B) A state science fair gold medal
- ☐ (C) Middle-school grand prize in NPR's Student Podcast Challenge
- ☐ (D) A school soccer championship

2. What is the name of Cora's podcast?

- ☐ (A) Dyslexia and MEE
- ☐ (B) Hunger Games Club
- ☐ (C) Reading Rockets
- ☐ (D) Brain Waves Daily

3. About how long did Cora say it took to get the correct diagnosis?

- ☐ (A) One summer
- ☐ (B) Almost five years
- ☐ (C) Ten days
- ☐ (D) Two weeks

4. How many submissions were chosen from?

- ☐ (A) Nearly 1,500
- ☐ (B) About 50
- ☐ (C) Exactly 42
- ☐ (D) More than 10,000

5. Where does Cora live?

- ☐ (A) San Jose, California
- ☐ (B) Washington, D.C.
- ☐ (C) Houston, Texas
- ☐ (D) Rockville Centre on Long Island, New York

6. What change did her mom notice this summer?

- ☐ (A) Cora quit tutoring
- ☐ (B) Cora read a Hunger Games book for fun
- ☐ (C) Cora moved to Princeton
- ☐ (D) Cora stopped needing school

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Cora Walsh: Says she feels excited, proud she kept trying, and hopes the podcast helps others.
2. Emily Johnson: Says she is proud of Cora's hard work and positive attitude.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):